



Q: Which law did she help frame as a member of the Rajya Sabha?

(1960)

A: Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act

Q: Which dance form was a male bastion till she started teaching it?

A: Nattuvangam

Q: Which ancient craft of textile printing is taught at Kalakshetra?

A: Kalamkari

Q: In which year was she awarded the Padma Bhushan?

A: 1956

Q: Where is Kalakshetra situated?

A: Adyar, near Chennai

animals in temples in and around Chennai. She turned to Indian dance only when the famed ballerina Anna Pavlova told her to look at India's indigenous forms for inspiration. She was 29 then and began to learn Bharatanatyam under Mylapore Gowri Amma and later from Guru Menakshisundrama Pillai of Pandanallur. She gave her first performance at the age of 31 at the annual convention of the Theosophical Society. By January 1936 she put in place the International Academy of Arts, which was subsequently renamed Kalakshetra. The academy was meant to resuscitate in modern India a recognition of our artistic traditions and would seek to impart to the young, "the true spirit of art", devoid of vulgarity and commercialism.

Born as Rukmini Nilakanta Sastry, Arundale helped reinvent Indian

classical dance, from sadir to what it is now called Bharatanatyam. Earlier it was associated with devadasis. She drew the attention of the erudite Indian to the genuine musical qualities of the dance by drawing upon the ritualistic and philosophical content intrinsic to the art form. Because of the decline of the devadasis and the promulgation of the Devadasi Abolition Act, 1948, she gave Bharatanatyam a social status it lacked in society at that time. Putting in place systematic gradations of study of the art form was the single-most outstanding thing she could have done for the country. Kalakshetra became a school of excellence because of the successive gurus who taught there—initially all trained by her. The focus was not on churning out only dancers of significance—it had other arts and crafts, too, on the curriculum. A normal



RAGHU RAI

academic school, The Besant Theosophical High School, fed the art academy. Weaving and spinning activities were as valid as any sport, dramatics, dance and, of course, music, both vocal and instrumental. The course included an understanding of languages—Sanskrit, Telugu and Tamil—and of the theory of dance and music, of the rituals associated with the temples where the art grew, of yoga and philosophy.

She was an innovator of the dance drama genre. She invited dance and music gurus to Kalakshetra and took pains to research the sacred texts with scholars of different languages. She requested them to compose dance dramas keeping in mind the aesthetic beauty and authenticity of particular village traditions. She tapped the geniuses to create works based upon the tenets of the *natyashastra*. Her works, however, held the traditions and yet departed from them handsomely and with such subtlety that viewers were left confounded by the results.

She replaced garish and often unaesthetic dance costume with simple but exquisitely designed costume and jewellery. Her presentations had beautiful settings. She had witnessed the best of the West as a young bride married to a Briton. He took her to museums and ballets, to chamber concerts and art galleries across the Europe. And she could not have had a better teacher than him. Years later, it showed in the particular finesse she brought to her works. When stagecraft and lights were only heard of in films, she brought in equipment like light boxes to enhance the appeal of a production. Traditional, one would say, but she was no conformist. When her father died, she opposed the tonsuring of her mother, a custom prevalent in the closed society. And when her husband died she continued to put vermilion on her forehead. She was a visionary who is a reference point for the young generation and for dance historians. A Renaissance woman, indeed.

The author, director of Kalakshetra Foundation, was a disciple of Arundale